

State of SAP Emergency Access & Compliance 2026

*How SAP-Running Enterprises Are Governing Firefighter Access,
Closing Audit Gaps & Building Compliance Resilience in the Age of AI*

North America



FIREFIGHTER
ACCESS
GOVERNANCE

Executive Summary

SAP Firefighter access — privileged emergency access to critical SAP systems — has become one of the most scrutinized audit areas in enterprise compliance. Yet most organizations continue to govern it with manual, reactive processes fundamentally misaligned to modern risk demands.



78%

Had a Firefighter audit finding in past 18 months



61%

Cannot produce complete audit trails in 48 hours



44%

Still rely on manual log review for oversight



23%

Achieved Level 3+ governance maturity (SEAMM)

Key Insight: Organizations with mature Firefighter governance report **67% fewer audit findings, 4x faster incident resolution & 52% lower compliance remediation costs** — yet 77% of enterprises remain below Level 3 maturity.

Industry Context & Regulatory Landscape

SAP Firefighter (Superuser Privilege Management) provides time-limited, elevated emergency access — designed for operational necessity, now a primary audit focus. With over 440,000 organizations running SAP globally, governance of this access is a board-level risk imperative.

SOX 302/404

Audit trails + timely controller review

SOC 1 / SOC 2

Logical access controls over full audit period

ISO 27001

Emergency access documentation & monitoring

GDPR

Personal data access accountability obligations

DORA (2025)

ICT risk management for financial services

NIST 800-53

AC-17 / AU-2 privileged access requirements

WHAT IS SAP FIREFIGHTER?



1. User requests Firefighter ID (FFID) for emergency



2. Multi-level approval via SAP GRC Access Control



3. Time-limited elevated access granted to FFID



4. All transactions logged in SAP audit trails



5. Controller reviews log within defined SLA (24–72 hrs)

5 Critical Governance Failure Modes

Most organizations face five interlocking governance failures that collectively define the Firefighter access gap in 2026



01 Identity Accountability Gap

Shared FFIDs make it near-impossible to trace actions to individuals without manual log correlation across 4–7 systems.

43% rely on manual reconciliation



02 Controller Review Bottleneck

Controllers receive logs but lack tools to evaluate appropriateness. In 37% of orgs, users review their own Firefighter logs.

37% have independence failure



03 Scope Creep Problem

FFIDs are provisioned with broad authorizations that persist for years, far exceeding documented emergency scenarios.

58% not reviewed in 12+ months



04 Audit Trail Fragmentation

Complete audit evidence is scattered across SAP GRC, SM20, ITSM, and email — requiring 8–40 hours to assemble per incident.

6.2 weeks avg to prepare evidence



05 S/4HANA Migration Blind Spot

71% of organizations that migrated to S/4HANA did not redesign their Firefighter governance framework, inheriting legacy risks.

71% carried forward legacy configs

Data-Driven Insights: Audit Exposure



Source: Maitsys 2026 SAP Emergency Access Survey (n=650)

Maitsys Point of View: 3 Paradigm Shifts Required

Maitsys POV: SAP emergency access governance is not an IT or GRC problem — it is a **strategic business risk management capability** that, when designed effectively, creates measurable operational value beyond audit compliance.



Shift 1

Periodic Review → Continuous Monitoring

Dynamic SAP landscapes require continuous monitoring — SIEM integration + AI anomaly detection — not 72-hour review cycles designed for static compliance models.



Shift 2

Isolated Controls → Integrated Risk Intelligence

Correlate Firefighter activity with SoD violations, change records, and business process flows for a unified risk intelligence picture that enables proactive management.



Shift 3

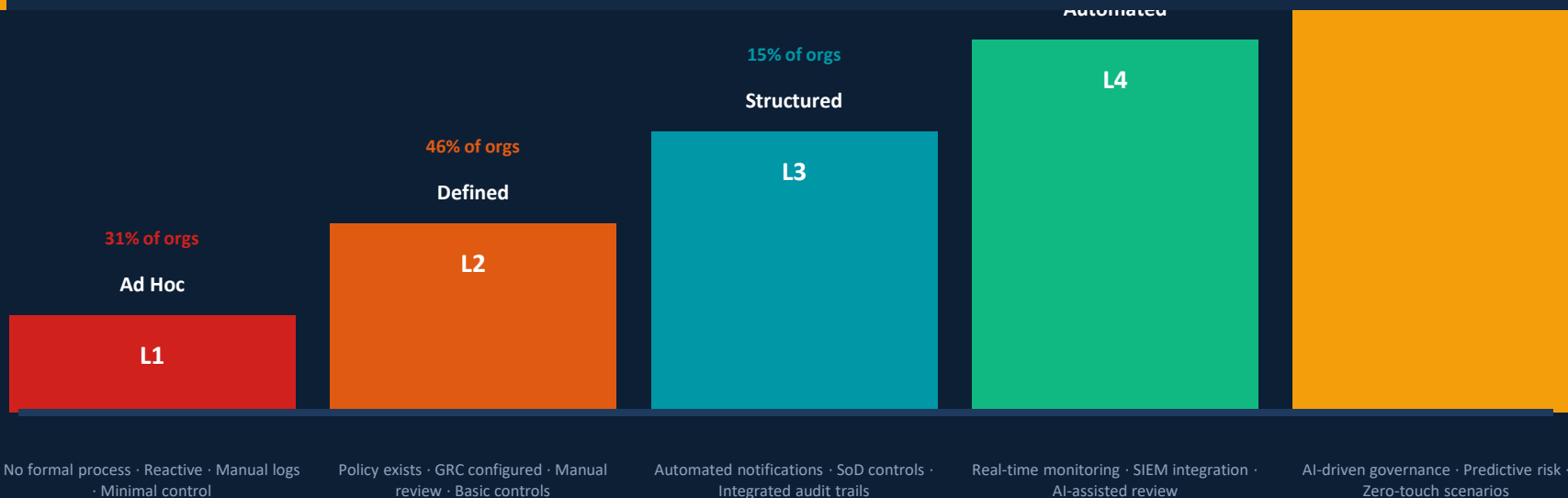
SAP-Centric → Ecosystem Governance

Emergency access now occurs through BTP extensions, APIs, RPA bots, and AI agents. Governance must extend to all privileged access pathways regardless of technical vector.

SEAMM: SAP Emergency Access Maturity Model

► INCREASING GOVERNANCE MATURITY ►

77% of enterprises are at Level 1–2. Moving to Level 3+ delivers 67% fewer audit findings, 4× faster resolution, and 52% lower remediation costs. *Maitsys SEAMM Assessment provides your current maturity score + personalized improvement roadmap.*



Governance Architecture: 5-Layer Framework



Layer 5 · Governance Analytics & Reporting

KPIs, trend analysis, executive dashboards, board reporting



Layer 4 · Audit Intelligence Platform

SM20/STAD/GRC log correlation, SIEM integration, real-time monitoring, forensic analysis



Layer 3 · Access Lifecycle Management

Request workflows, multi-level approval, session monitoring, controller review, certification



Layer 2 · Risk Intelligence Engine

Real-time SoD analysis, combined risk scoring, anomaly detection, threat intelligence



Layer 1 · Identity Foundation

Authoritative FFID inventory, IGA integration, entitlement lifecycle governance

Actionable Recommendations for SAP & IT Leaders

IMMEDIATE

0 – 90 Days

- 1 Conduct SEAMM maturity assessment
- 2 Inventory & rationalize FFID portfolio
- 3 Resolve controller independence failures

NEAR-TERM

90 Days – 12 Months

- 1 Automate risk analysis at point of request
- 2 Implement quarterly FFID access certification
- 3 Integrate FF logs with SIEM / audit platform

STRATEGIC

12 – 36 Months

- 1 Extend governance to SAP BTP & cloud ecosystem
- 2 Deploy AI-augmented log analysis & anomaly detection
- 3 Build board-level governance reporting capability

Outlook: 6 Trends Reshaping SAP Governance



01 AI-Native SAP Landscape

SAP Joule AI agents can autonomously execute transactions. By 2028, AI-related FF scenarios will be the fastest-growing governance category.



02 Regulatory Convergence

DORA (Jan 2025), EU AI Act, and ESG reporting obligations are multiplying compliance requirements for SAP privileged access governance.



03 Zero Trust Architecture

Zero Trust in SAP means continuous session verification, context-aware access, and JIT provisioning eliminating standing FFID entitlements.



04 Agentic AI in SAP Ops

AI agents performing multi-step SAP operations challenge the human-centric Firefighter model. New governance paradigms required by 2027.



05 GRC + SOC Convergence

SAP threat actors use FFID vectors for persistence. 34% of SAP-targeted attacks exploit privileged access gaps. GRC & SOC must converge.



06 S/4HANA Reset Window

Migrations through 2027 offer a critical governance redesign window. Organizations that act proactively establish multi-year compliance advantages.

SAP SECURITY PRACTICE

What's Next

The 3 Mandates for 2026



1. Know Your Current State

Complete an SEAMM assessment before investing in technology. Organizations with baseline assessments achieve target maturity 40% faster.



2. Automate the Foundation

Automate risk analysis at point of request, controller workflows, and audit trail management. Highest near-term ROI, foundational for AI.



3. Design for the Future

S/4HANA migrations are your governance reset window. Design AI-ready, ecosystem-aware frameworks now — not after the next audit finding.

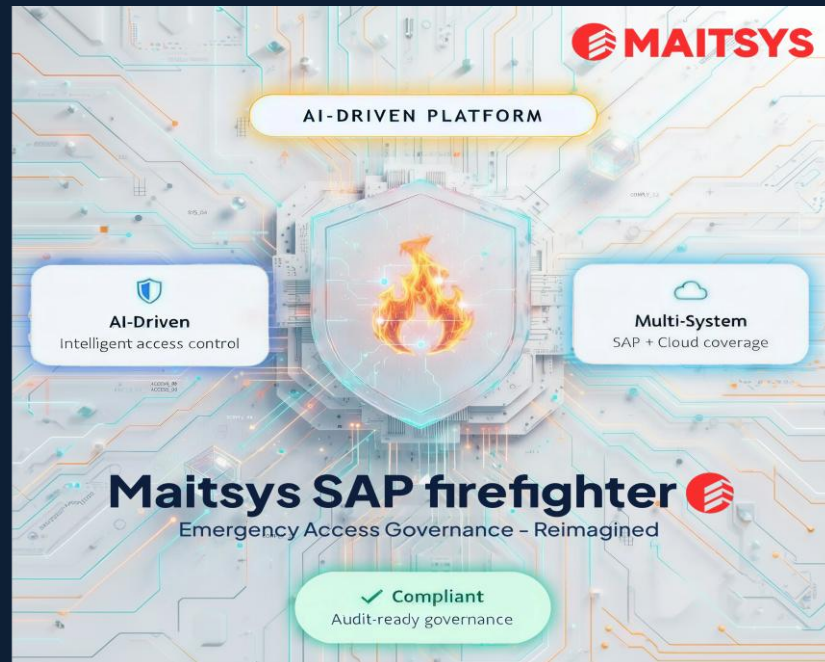


Introducing Maitsys SAP Firefighter

An AI-driven platform designed to modernize emergency access management across complex SAP environments

Elevating SAP Access Governance

- ▶ Instant, policy-based emergency access approvals
- ▶ AI-driven risk scoring and anomaly detection
- ▶ Automated workflows to reduce manual intervention
- ▶ Comprehensive audit trails for compliance readiness





Maitsys SAP Firefighter: Platform Capabilities

Reimagining privileged access for modern SAP environments



AI-Powered Workflows

AI-powered request & approval workflows with intelligent routing and policy enforcement



Mobile Approvals

Secure, mobile-friendly approvals for controllers — anytime, anywhere



Real-Time Visibility

Real-time visibility into privileged activity with automated log review and risk scoring



Auditor Dashboards

Auditor-ready dashboards for instant compliance evidence



The Maitsys Difference: Measurable Outcomes

The result of deploying Maitsys SAP Firefighter across your SAP landscape

4x

Faster Emergency
Access Approvals

360°

Visibility into Privileged
Activities

Auto

Compliance Reporting

60%

Reduced Operational
Overhead

Ready to Transform Your SAP Emergency Access Governance?

Contact Maitsys SAP Security Practice for a personalized demo

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